



Cars of the World

48 cars that changed how the world drives

From the Ford Model T to the electric age, across 12 countries



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One car per page, grouped by the country where it was made. The colour on each page shows its region.

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Ford Model T

Ford Motor Company | 1908 - 1927

At a glance

Maker	Ford Motor Company
Country	United States
Years built	1908 - 1927
Engine	2.9 L four-cylinder
Power	20 hp
Number built	About 15 million

The story

Henry Ford wanted a car that ordinary working families could afford, and the Model T was the answer. It was simple, tough and easy to repair, with high ground clearance for the rough country roads of the time. In 1913 Ford introduced the moving assembly line at its Highland Park plant, which cut the time to build a car from about twelve hours to around ninety minutes.

Why it matters

The Model T turned the car from a toy for the rich into everyday transport. Its price fell from \$850 at launch to around \$260 by the mid-1920s, and the production methods Ford developed for it were copied by factories in almost every industry.

Did you know? At its peak, roughly half of all cars on the world's roads were Model Ts.

Willys MB 'Jeep'

Willys-Overland (and Ford) | 1941 - 1945

At a glance

Maker	Willys-Overland (and Ford)
Country	United States
Years built	1941 - 1945
Engine	2.2 L 'Go Devil' four-cylinder
Power	60 hp
Number built	About 640,000 (Willys and Ford combined)

The story

The US Army asked for a light four-wheel-drive reconnaissance vehicle in 1940, with an almost impossible deadline. Bantam built the first prototype, but Willys-Overland won the main contract, and Ford built a near-identical version called the GPW. The result was small, light, flat-sided and able to go almost anywhere, from North African desert to Pacific jungle.

Why it matters

The wartime Jeep became the parent of every civilian off-roader that followed. After the war, Willys turned it into the CJ series for farmers and adventurers, and the Jeep brand is still built around the same seven-slot grille today.

Did you know? Nobody is completely sure where the name 'jeep' came from. One popular theory is that it grew out of the letters 'GP', army shorthand for 'general purpose'.

Chevrolet Corvette

Chevrolet (General Motors) | 1953 - present

At a glance

Maker	Chevrolet (General Motors)
Country	United States
Years built	1953 - present
Engine	Originally a 3.9 L 'Blue Flame' six-cylinder
Power	150 hp (1953)
Number built	Well over 1.5 million across eight generations

The story

GM designer Harley Earl wanted an American answer to the European sports cars that returning soldiers had fallen for. The first Corvette arrived in 1953 with a lightweight fibreglass body, and only 300 were built that year, all hand-assembled. Engineer Zora Arkus-Duntov later added V8 power and turned it into a serious performance car.

Why it matters

The Corvette is America's longest-running sports car nameplate. In 2020 the eighth generation (C8) moved the engine behind the driver for the first time, bringing mid-engine layout to a car that still costs far less than most European rivals.

Did you know? Every one of the 300 Corvettes built in 1953 was painted Polo White with a red interior.

Ford Mustang

Ford Motor Company | 1964 - present

At a glance

Maker	Ford Motor Company
Country	United States
Years built	1964 - present
Engine	From a 2.8 L six-cylinder to a 4.7 L V8 (1964)
Power	Up to 271 hp (1964)
Number built	More than 10 million

The story

Lee Iacocca pushed for a sporty, affordable car aimed at the young baby-boom generation. Built largely on the parts of the humble Ford Falcon, the Mustang was unveiled at the New York World's Fair on 17 April 1964. Ford took around 22,000 orders on the first day, and sold its millionth Mustang within about two years.

Why it matters

The Mustang created a whole new category, the 'pony car': a long bonnet, a short rear, and a long list of options so buyers could make it their own. Rivals like the Chevrolet Camaro and Dodge Challenger were built to answer it.

Did you know? The car famously starred in the 1968 film 'Bullitt', whose car chase through San Francisco is still counted among the best ever filmed.

Shelby Cobra

AC Cars / Shelby American | 1962 - 1967

At a glance

Maker	AC Cars / Shelby American
Country	United States / United Kingdom
Years built	1962 - 1967
Engine	4.7 L and 7.0 L Ford V8
Power	Up to about 425 hp (427 version)
Number built	About 1,000

The story

Texan racing driver Carroll Shelby had a simple idea: take the small, light AC Ace roadster from Britain and fit it with a powerful American Ford V8. AC had just lost its engine supplier, so the timing was perfect. The result was brutally fast and became a winner in sports car racing through the mid-1960s.

Why it matters

The Cobra showed that British chassis engineering and American horsepower made a winning mix. It is one of the most copied cars ever, with thousands of replicas built by kit-car makers around the world.

Did you know? In 1965 the Cobra-based Daytona Coupe won the World Sportscar Championship GT class, the first American manufacturer's title at that level.

Ford GT40

Ford Motor Company | 1964 - 1969

At a glance

Maker	Ford Motor Company
Country	United States / United Kingdom
Years built	1964 - 1969
Engine	4.7 L and 7.0 L V8
Power	About 485 hp (Mk II)
Number built	About 105

The story

After a deal to buy Ferrari fell apart in 1963, Henry Ford II set out to beat Ferrari at the 24 Hours of Le Mans. Ford poured money into a low, mid-engine race car developed in England and the United States. Early versions struggled, but the big-engined Mk II finally delivered.

Why it matters

In 1966 GT40s finished first, second and third at Le Mans, ending Ferrari's run of wins. Ford then won the race four years in a row, from 1966 to 1969, one of the great comeback stories in motorsport.

Did you know? The name comes from its height: the car stood just 40 inches (about 1 metre) tall.

Tesla Model S

Tesla | 2012 - present

At a glance

Maker	Tesla
Country	United States
Years built	2012 - present
Engine	Electric motors (single, dual, and triple)
Power	Over 1,000 hp (Plaid version)
Number built	Hundreds of thousands

The story

Before the Model S, most electric cars were small, slow and short on range. Tesla built a large, fast luxury saloon with a battery pack in the floor, a huge touchscreen, and software updates delivered over the air. It could travel hundreds of kilometres on a charge and was backed by Tesla's own fast-charging network.

Why it matters

The Model S made the rest of the car industry take electric cars seriously. Within a few years almost every major manufacturer had announced its own long-range electric models.

Did you know? It was named Motor Trend Car of the Year for 2013, the first car without a petrol or diesel engine to win.

Rolls-Royce Silver Ghost

Rolls-Royce | 1906 - 1926

At a glance

Maker	Rolls-Royce
Country	United Kingdom
Years built	1906 - 1926
Engine	7.0 L (later 7.4 L) six-cylinder
Power	About 50 hp
Number built	About 7,900

The story

The name first belonged to a single demonstration car, painted silver with silver-plated fittings, but it soon stuck to the whole model. Rolls-Royce set out to prove it was the most reliable car available, and in 1907 it drove nearly 15,000 miles, most of it between London and Glasgow, under official observation with barely any trouble.

Why it matters

The Silver Ghost built the Rolls-Royce reputation for quiet, smooth and dependable luxury that the brand still trades on. Its chassis was so strong that it was turned into armoured cars during the First World War.

Did you know? It was so quiet for its time that people said the loudest thing you could hear while driving was the ticking of the clock.

Land Rover Series I

Rover Company | 1948 - 1958 (Series); Defender to 2016

At a glance

Maker	Rover Company
Country	United Kingdom
Years built	1948 - 1958 (Series); Defender to 2016
Engine	1.6 L four-cylinder
Power	50 hp
Number built	Over 2 million of the original line

The story

After the Second World War, steel was rationed in Britain but aluminium was easier to get. Rover's chief designer Maurice Wilks, inspired by the Jeep he used on his farm, sketched a simple utility vehicle, and his team built it with aluminium body panels. It was launched at the Amsterdam Motor Show in 1948.

Why it matters

Meant as a stop-gap product for farmers, it became one of the world's great working vehicles, used by armies, aid agencies and explorers. The line evolved into the Defender, which was built until 2016 and then reborn in a new form in 2020.

Did you know? The first outline of the Land Rover is said to have been drawn in the sand on a beach in Anglesey, Wales.

Mini

British Motor Corporation | 1959 - 2000

At a glance

Maker	British Motor Corporation
Country	United Kingdom
Years built	1959 - 2000
Engine	848 cc four-cylinder (launch)
Power	34 hp (launch)
Number built	About 5.3 million

The story

The 1956 fuel crisis created demand for small, economical cars. Engineer Alec Issigonis turned the engine sideways and put the gearbox underneath it, driving the front wheels. That left room for four adults inside a car only about three metres long, with a wheel at each corner.

Why it matters

That transverse, front-wheel-drive layout is now used by most small and family cars in the world. The Mini also became a 1960s style icon and a giant-killer in motorsport, with Mini Coopers winning the Monte Carlo Rally in 1964, 1965 and 1967.

Did you know? Around 80 percent of the car's floor space was given to passengers and luggage.

Jaguar E-Type

Jaguar | 1961 - 1975

At a glance

Maker	Jaguar
Country	United Kingdom
Years built	1961 - 1975
Engine	3.8 L six-cylinder (launch)
Power	265 hp (claimed, launch)
Number built	About 72,500

The story

The E-Type drew on Jaguar's Le Mans-winning D-Type race car, with a long, low body shaped by aerodynamicist Malcolm Sayer. When it was revealed at the Geneva Motor Show in 1961, it offered the look and speed of an exotic car at a fraction of the price of its rivals.

Why it matters

Few cars have made such a strong first impression. The E-Type combined beauty, speed and relative affordability, and it became a symbol of 1960s Britain.

Did you know? An E-Type roadster is part of the permanent design collection at the Museum of Modern Art in New York.

Aston Martin DB5

Aston Martin | 1963 - 1965

At a glance

Maker	Aston Martin
Country	United Kingdom
Years built	1963 - 1965
Engine	4.0 L six-cylinder
Power	282 hp
Number built	Just over 1,000

The story

The DB5 was a refined evolution of the DB4, with an aluminium body built with Italian coachbuilder Touring's lightweight method. It was fast, handsome and very expensive, the kind of grand tourer made for crossing continents in style.

Why it matters

Its fame comes largely from the screen. After appearing in the James Bond film 'Goldfinger' in 1964, fitted with gadgets for the story, the DB5 became arguably the most famous car in cinema and turned Aston Martin into a household name.

Did you know? Aston Martin later built a small batch of new 'continuation' DB5s with working film-style gadgets.

Range Rover

Rover Company / Land Rover | 1970 - present

At a glance

Maker	Rover Company / Land Rover
Country	United Kingdom
Years built	1970 - present
Engine	3.5 L V8 (launch)
Power	About 130 hp (launch)
Number built	Well over 1 million across generations

The story

Rover engineers wanted a vehicle that could go off road like a Land Rover but ride and drive comfortably on the motorway. The first Range Rover combined coil-spring suspension, permanent four-wheel drive and a lightweight V8 engine in a clean, simple body.

Why it matters

It is widely seen as the first luxury SUV. Almost every premium sport utility vehicle on the road today follows the idea it introduced: go anywhere, and arrive in comfort.

Did you know? In 1971 a Range Rover was displayed at the Louvre in Paris as an example of fine industrial design.

McLaren F1

McLaren Automotive | 1992 - 1998

At a glance

Maker	McLaren Automotive
Country	United Kingdom
Years built	1992 - 1998
Engine	6.1 L BMW V12
Power	627 PS
Number built	106

The story

Designer Gordon Murray set out to build the ultimate road car, with no compromises. The F1 had a carbon-fibre body, a central driving seat with a passenger on each side, and a naturally aspirated V12 engine from BMW. It was light, beautifully engineered and extremely fast.

Why it matters

In 1998 it reached about 386 km/h (240 mph), making it the fastest production car in the world for years. A racing version won the 24 Hours of Le Mans in 1995 at its first attempt.

Did you know? The engine bay is lined with gold foil, because gold is one of the best materials for reflecting heat.

Volkswagen Beetle

Volkswagen | 1938 - 2003

At a glance

Maker	Volkswagen
Country	Germany
Years built	1938 - 2003
Engine	Air-cooled flat-four, 1.0 to 1.6 L
Power	25 to 50 hp
Number built	About 21.5 million

The story

Designed by Ferdinand Porsche's team in the 1930s as a 'people's car', the Beetle only reached mass production after the Second World War. With a rear-mounted air-cooled engine, a rounded body and simple mechanics, it was cheap to buy and easy to keep running.

Why it matters

The Beetle became a global car, built and sold in dozens of countries and loved for its reliability and personality. Clever advertising in the United States in the 1960s turned its small size and odd shape into selling points.

Did you know? In 1972 it passed the Ford Model T as the best-selling car in history. The final original Beetle was built in Puebla, Mexico, in 2003.

Mercedes-Benz 300 SL 'Gullwing'

Mercedes-Benz | 1954 - 1957

At a glance

Maker	Mercedes-Benz
Country	Germany
Years built	1954 - 1957
Engine	3.0 L six-cylinder, fuel-injected
Power	215 hp
Number built	About 1,400 coupes

The story

The 300 SL grew out of a successful racing car. Its frame was made of a web of thin steel tubes, which made it light and stiff but left very high, wide sills along the sides. Normal doors would not work, so the engineers hinged them at the roof, and they opened upwards like wings.

Why it matters

It was one of the fastest road cars of its day and the first production car with direct fuel injection, a technology now found in many modern petrol engines.

Did you know? The car's American importer, Max Hoffman, persuaded Mercedes to build a road version, convinced that wealthy US buyers would want it.

Trabant

VEB Sachsenring | 1957 - 1991

At a glance

Maker	VEB Sachsenring
Country	Germany (East)
Years built	1957 - 1991
Engine	0.6 L two-stroke twin
Power	About 26 hp
Number built	About 3 million

The story

East Germany needed an affordable car but had little steel to spare. The Trabant used a body made of Duroplast, a plastic reinforced with waste cotton fibres, over a steel frame. Its smoky two-stroke engine was simple and noisy, and the design barely changed for decades.

Why it matters

For millions of East Germans it was the only realistic car to own. When the Berlin Wall fell in 1989, long lines of Trabants crossing into the West became one of the defining images of the moment.

Did you know? Buyers often waited ten years or more for their new Trabant to be delivered.

Porsche 911

Porsche | 1964 - present

At a glance

Maker	Porsche
Country	Germany
Years built	1964 - present
Engine	Flat-six mounted at the rear
Power	130 hp (1964); well over 600 hp today
Number built	More than 1 million

The story

The 911 replaced the Porsche 356, keeping its rear-engine layout but adding a six-cylinder engine and a new shape by Ferdinand Alexander 'Butzi' Porsche. Over sixty years it has been refined again and again, yet it is still instantly recognisable.

Why it matters

Few cars have been built for so long while keeping the same basic idea. The 911 has won countless races and rallies and remains the benchmark everyday sports car.

Did you know? It was first shown as the '901', but Peugeot held the rights to three-digit car names with a zero in the middle, so Porsche changed it to 911.

Volkswagen Golf

Volkswagen | 1974 - present

At a glance

Maker	Volkswagen
Country	Germany
Years built	1974 - present
Engine	1.1 to 1.6 L four-cylinder (first generation)
Power	50 to 110 hp (first generation)
Number built	More than 35 million

The story

Volkswagen needed a modern successor to the Beetle. The Golf, styled by Giorgetto Giugiaro, had its engine in the front, drove the front wheels and had a practical hatchback. It was roomy, sensible and good to drive.

Why it matters

The Golf defined the modern family hatchback in Europe. In 1976 the Golf GTI, first developed by a small group of engineers in their spare time, created the 'hot hatch': a practical everyday car with real sports car performance.

Did you know? The Golf is one of the best-selling car nameplates in history and is now in its eighth generation.

BMW 3 Series

BMW | 1975 - present

At a glance

Maker	BMW
Country	Germany
Years built	1975 - present
Engine	Four and six-cylinder engines
Power	From about 75 hp up to over 500 hp (M3)
Number built	More than 15 million

The story

The first 3 Series replaced BMW's small 02 series and set the recipe the model still follows: a compact saloon with rear-wheel drive, sharp handling and a focus on the driver.

Why it matters

The 3 Series became the standard that other compact premium saloons are measured against. The first M3, launched in 1986, was built to go touring car racing and became one of the most successful racing cars of its era.

Did you know? The 3 Series has long been BMW's best-selling model.

Mercedes-Benz S-Class

Mercedes-Benz | 1972 - present (as S-Class)

At a glance

Maker	Mercedes-Benz
Country	Germany
Years built	1972 - present (as S-Class)
Engine	Six-, eight- and twelve-cylinder, hybrid
Power	Varies by generation
Number built	Several million

The story

Mercedes has built large luxury saloons for most of its history, but the name S-Class was first used officially on the W116 generation in 1972. Each new generation has been the company's flagship and its showcase for new technology.

Why it matters

The S-Class has introduced many features that later spread to ordinary cars. It was one of the first production cars to offer electronic anti-lock brakes (1978) and a driver's airbag (1981).

Did you know? The 'S' stands for Sonderklasse, German for 'special class'.

Audi Quattro

Audi | 1980 - 1991

At a glance

Maker	Audi
Country	Germany
Years built	1980 - 1991
Engine	2.1 L turbocharged five-cylinder
Power	200 hp (road car)
Number built	About 11,500

The story

Audi engineers noticed that a four-wheel-drive military vehicle could out-grip powerful cars on snow. They built permanent four-wheel drive into a fast turbocharged coupe and unveiled it at the Geneva Motor Show in 1980.

Why it matters

In the World Rally Championship, the Quattro showed that four-wheel drive was the way to win. It took drivers' and manufacturers' titles in the early 1980s, and today four-wheel drive is common on performance cars and everyday cars alike.

Did you know? 'Quattro' is Italian for 'four', a reference to the four driven wheels.

Citroen 2CV

Citroen | 1948 - 1990

At a glance

Maker	Citroen
Country	France
Years built	1948 - 1990
Engine	375 cc air-cooled twin (launch)
Power	9 hp (launch)
Number built	About 3.9 million

The story

Before the war, Citroen set out to build a car for French farmers. The brief asked for a car that could carry four people and a load of goods, and drive across a ploughed field with a basket of eggs without breaking any. The result had soft long-travel suspension, a canvas roof and very few parts.

Why it matters

The 2CV gave rural France its first affordable car and stayed in production for 42 years. Its extreme simplicity and cheerful looks made it a cult car around the world.

Did you know? '2CV' means 'deux chevaux', or 'two horses', a reference to its French tax horsepower rating.

Peugeot 205

Peugeot | 1983 - 1998

At a glance

Maker	Peugeot
Country	France
Years built	1983 - 1998
Engine	1.0 to 1.9 L four-cylinder
Power	Up to 130 hp (GTI)
Number built	About 5.3 million

The story

Peugeot was in financial trouble in the early 1980s and needed a hit. The 205 was a small, light, well-styled hatchback that was fun to drive and cheap to run. The sporty GTI version quickly became one of the best-loved hot hatches.

Why it matters

The 205 is widely credited with rescuing Peugeot. Its rally version, the 205 Turbo 16, won the World Rally Championship in 1985 and 1986.

Did you know? The 205 stayed in production for 15 years with only small changes to its styling.

Bugatti Veyron

Bugatti (Volkswagen Group) | 2005 - 2015

At a glance

Maker	Bugatti (Volkswagen Group)
Country	France
Years built	2005 - 2015
Engine	8.0 L quad-turbocharged W16
Power	1,001 PS
Number built	450

The story

Volkswagen chairman Ferdinand Piech set his engineers an extreme target: more than 1,000 horsepower and a top speed over 400 km/h, in a car that could still be driven comfortably in town. Solving that took years of work on cooling, tyres and stability.

Why it matters

The Veyron reset the idea of what a road car could do. It was the fastest production car in the world when it launched, and the Super Sport version later reached 431 km/h.

Did you know? The car needs ten radiators to keep its engine, gearbox and other systems cool.

Fiat 500

Fiat | 1957 - 1975

At a glance

Maker	Fiat
Country	Italy
Years built	1957 - 1975
Engine	479 cc air-cooled twin (launch)
Power	13 hp (launch)
Number built	About 4 million

The story

Engineer Dante Giacosa designed the tiny 500 to give Italian families an alternative to the scooter. It had a rear-mounted two-cylinder engine, a fold-back fabric roof and just enough room for four people who were friendly with each other.

Why it matters

The 500 put post-war Italy on four wheels and became part of the country's image, from narrow city streets to film scenes. It proved that a very small car could still have huge character.

Did you know? Fiat launched a modern 500 in 2007, exactly fifty years after the original.

Ferrari 250 GTO

Ferrari | 1962 - 1964

At a glance

Maker	Ferrari
Country	Italy
Years built	1962 - 1964
Engine	3.0 L V12
Power	About 300 hp
Number built	36

The story

The 250 GTO was built to compete in the GT class of sports car racing. Its body was shaped in a wind tunnel and it was light, powerful and beautifully balanced. It won the GT championship three years in a row.

Why it matters

It is often called the most desirable car in the world. Because so few were made and they are so admired, 250 GTOs are among the most valuable cars ever sold.

Did you know? In 2018 one example sold at auction for more than \$48 million.

Lamborghini Miura

Lamborghini | 1966 - 1973

At a glance

Maker	Lamborghini
Country	Italy
Years built	1966 - 1973
Engine	3.9 L V12, mounted sideways behind the cabin
Power	350 to 385 hp
Number built	About 760

The story

A small group of young Lamborghini engineers built the chassis in their spare time, placing a V12 sideways behind the seats. Marcello Gandini at the design house Bertone gave it a low, flowing body. The car caused a sensation when it was shown in 1966.

Why it matters

The Miura is often credited with starting the supercar era: a mid-engined road car built for speed, drama and looks.

Did you know? It is named after Eduardo Miura, a famous breeder of Spanish fighting bulls.

Lancia Stratos

Lancia | 1973 - 1978

At a glance

Maker	Lancia
Country	Italy
Years built	1973 - 1978
Engine	2.4 L Ferrari Dino V6
Power	About 190 hp (road car)
Number built	About 490

The story

Most rally cars of the time were modified road cars. Lancia did it the other way round, designing a car purely to win rallies and then building the small number of road versions required by the rules. It had a short wheelbase, a mid-mounted Ferrari engine and a striking wedge-shaped body by Bertone.

Why it matters

The Stratos won the World Rally Championship for manufacturers three years in a row, from 1974 to 1976. It showed how much a purpose-built design could win.

Did you know? Its body was designed by Marcello Gandini, who also designed the Miura and the Countach.

Lamborghini Countach

Lamborghini | 1974 - 1990

At a glance

Maker	Lamborghini
Country	Italy
Years built	1974 - 1990
Engine	V12, from 3.9 L to 5.2 L
Power	375 to 455 hp
Number built	About 2,000

The story

Gandini followed the flowing Miura with something completely different: a sharp, flat wedge with doors that swung upward. The Countach looked like nothing else on the road and grew ever more extreme during its sixteen years, adding wings, vents and wider wheels.

Why it matters

It became the poster car of a generation and fixed the idea of what a supercar should look like: low, angular, loud and a little impractical.

Did you know? The name comes from an expression of amazement in the Piedmontese dialect of northern Italy.

Volvo 240

Volvo | 1974 - 1993

At a glance

Maker	Volvo
Country	Sweden
Years built	1974 - 1993
Engine	2.0 to 2.3 L four-cylinder, and others
Power	About 100 to 155 hp
Number built	About 2.8 million

The story

The 240 was a boxy, solid saloon and estate car built with safety as its top priority, including large crumple zones front and rear. It stayed in production for almost twenty years with only minor changes.

Why it matters

The 240 helped fix Volvo's worldwide reputation for safety and durability. The brand had already given the world the modern three-point seat belt, invented by Volvo engineer Nils Bohlin in 1959.

Did you know? Volvo made the three-point seat belt patent free for other car makers to use, a decision estimated to have saved many lives.

Koenigsegg Agera RS

Koenigsegg | 2015 - 2018

At a glance

Maker	Koenigsegg
Country	Sweden
Years built	2015 - 2018
Engine	5.0 L twin-turbocharged V8
Power	About 1,160 hp
Number built	25

The story

Christian von Koenigsegg founded his company in 1994 with the dream of building a world-class supercar in Sweden. The Agera RS was a lightweight, carbon-fibre hypercar built in tiny numbers, largely by hand.

Why it matters

In November 2017 an Agera RS set a two-way average speed of about 447 km/h on a closed public road in Nevada, USA. It showed that a small Swedish company could beat the world's biggest names at their own game.

Did you know? Koenigsegg's factory is on a former fighter jet base, and the company's ghost logo honours the squadron that was based there.

VAZ-2101 'Zhiguli'

AvtoVAZ | 1970 - 1988

At a glance

Maker	AvtoVAZ
Country	Soviet Union (Russia)
Years built	1970 - 1988
Engine	1.2 L four-cylinder
Power	About 64 hp
Number built	Millions

The story

The Soviet government signed a deal with Fiat to build a version of the Fiat 124 in a vast new factory in the city of Togliatti. The car was strengthened for harsh Russian winters and poor roads, with a heavier body and a starting handle in case the battery failed.

Why it matters

It became the car of the Soviet people and the foundation of the Lada brand. Its descendants were built for decades and exported around the world.

Did you know? Later versions of the same basic design, such as the Lada 2107, stayed in production in Russia until 2012.

Toyota Land Cruiser

Toyota | 1951 - present

At a glance

Maker	Toyota
Country	Japan
Years built	1951 - present
Engine	Many petrol and diesel engines
Power	Varies by generation
Number built	More than 10 million

The story

Toyota's first four-wheel-drive vehicle was built as a potential military and police vehicle in the early 1950s. The name Land Cruiser arrived in 1954. Over the decades it grew from a basic utility vehicle into a family of tough off-roaders and comfortable SUVs.

Why it matters

The Land Cruiser is trusted in some of the hardest places on Earth, from deserts and mining sites to disaster zones. Its reputation for reliability has made it a favourite of aid agencies and remote communities.

Did you know? In 1951, a prototype became the first motor vehicle to climb to the sixth station of Mount Fuji.

Toyota Corolla

Toyota | 1966 - present

At a glance

Maker	Toyota
Country	Japan
Years built	1966 - present
Engine	1.1 L four-cylinder (launch)
Power	60 hp (launch)
Number built	More than 50 million

The story

The first Corolla was designed as an affordable family car for Japan's growing middle class. Toyota aimed to give it slightly more than buyers expected, including a bigger engine than its main rival. It was reliable, economical and easy to live with.

Why it matters

The Corolla is the best-selling car nameplate in history. It has been built in many countries and sold in more than 150 markets, becoming a symbol of dependable Japanese manufacturing.

Did you know? The name 'Corolla' refers to the ring of petals in a flower, following Toyota's crown-themed naming (the Crown and the Corona).

Datsun 240Z

Nissan (sold as Datsun) | 1969 - 1973

At a glance

Maker	Nissan (sold as Datsun)
Country	Japan
Years built	1969 - 1973
Engine	2.4 L six-cylinder
Power	151 hp
Number built	About 150,000

The story

Yutaka Katayama, the head of Nissan's US operations and known as 'Mr K', pushed for an affordable sports car with the style of a European GT. The 240Z had a long bonnet, a six-cylinder engine and independent suspension, all at a price far below most rivals.

Why it matters

It proved that Japan could build exciting sports cars, not just economical family cars. It sold in huge numbers in the United States and started the long-running Z car family.

Did you know? In Japan the car was sold as the Nissan Fairlady Z.

Honda Civic

Honda | 1972 - present

At a glance

Maker	Honda
Country	Japan
Years built	1972 - present
Engine	1.2 L four-cylinder (launch)
Power	About 50 hp (launch)
Number built	More than 25 million

The story

Honda was better known for motorcycles when it launched the small, front-wheel-drive Civic. It arrived just before the 1973 oil crisis, when drivers everywhere suddenly wanted cars that used less fuel.

Why it matters

Honda's CVCC engine, offered in the Civic, met strict US emission rules without needing a catalytic converter, which established Honda as a serious car maker. Today the Civic is one of the most successful car names in the world.

Did you know? Soichiro Honda founded his company in 1948 making motorised bicycles.

Nissan Skyline GT-R (R32)

Nissan | 1989 - 1994

At a glance

Maker	Nissan
Country	Japan
Years built	1989 - 1994
Engine	2.6 L twin-turbo six-cylinder
Power	280 PS (official)
Number built	About 43,000

The story

Nissan built the R32 GT-R to win Group A touring car racing. It used a clever computer-controlled four-wheel-drive system that could send power to the front wheels when needed, and a strong turbocharged engine that tuners could push far beyond its official output.

Why it matters

It dominated touring car racing in Japan and Australia and became a legend among tuning fans worldwide. Its success laid the foundation for the later GT-R models.

Did you know? Australian motoring press nicknamed it 'Godzilla', the monster from Japan, and the name has stuck to every GT-R since.

Honda NSX

Honda | 1990 - 2005

At a glance

Maker	Honda
Country	Japan
Years built	1990 - 2005
Engine	3.0 L V6 with VTEC
Power	270 hp
Number built	About 18,000

The story

Honda wanted to prove it could build a supercar as good as Ferrari's, but easier to live with. The NSX had an aluminium body and chassis, a mid-mounted V6 and a spacious, comfortable cabin with excellent visibility.

Why it matters

It showed that a supercar could be reliable and usable every day. Rival manufacturers had to improve the quality and comfort of their own cars in response.

Did you know? Formula One champion Ayrton Senna tested the prototype and encouraged Honda to make the chassis stiffer.

Mazda MX-5

Mazda | 1989 - present

At a glance

Maker	Mazda
Country	Japan
Years built	1989 - present
Engine	1.6 L four-cylinder (launch)
Power	115 hp (launch)
Number built	More than 1 million

The story

By the late 1980s the classic small British roadster had almost disappeared. Mazda revived the idea with a light, simple, rear-wheel-drive two-seater with a folding roof, and made it reliable in a way the old British cars were not.

Why it matters

The MX-5 is the best-selling two-seat sports car in history. It brought back the joy of the affordable roadster and inspired a wave of rivals.

Did you know? Mazda's engineers built it around the idea of 'jinba ittai', a Japanese phrase meaning horse and rider as one.

Toyota Prius

Toyota | 1997 - present

At a glance

Maker	Toyota
Country	Japan
Years built	1997 - present
Engine	Petrol engine plus electric motor (hybrid)
Power	Varies by generation
Number built	Millions

The story

The Prius was launched in Japan in 1997 as the world's first mass-produced hybrid car. It combined a petrol engine with an electric motor and battery, switching between them automatically to save fuel.

Why it matters

It made hybrid technology mainstream and showed that cleaner cars could be practical for everyday use. Hybrid systems based on its technology are now used across Toyota's range and beyond.

Did you know? 'Prius' is a Latin word meaning 'to go before', chosen because it came ahead of its time.

Nissan Leaf

Nissan | 2010 - present

At a glance

Maker	Nissan
Country	Japan
Years built	2010 - present
Engine	Electric motor
Power	About 110 hp (launch)
Number built	Hundreds of thousands

The story

Nissan designed the Leaf from the start as an electric car for ordinary families, not a luxury item. It was a practical five-door hatchback that could be charged at home.

Why it matters

The Leaf was one of the first mass-market electric cars and for years it was the world's best-selling electric car. It helped prove that electric motoring could work for everyday drivers.

Did you know? Nissan has said the name stands for 'Leading, Environmentally friendly, Affordable, Family car'.

Hyundai Pony

Hyundai | 1975 - 1990

At a glance

Maker	Hyundai
Country	South Korea
Years built	1975 - 1990
Engine	1.2 to 1.4 L four-cylinder (Mitsubishi-based)
Power	About 80 hp
Number built	Hundreds of thousands

The story

The Pony was South Korea's first mass-produced car designed for the country. Hyundai hired Italian designer Giorgetto Giugiaro for the styling and licensed engines and parts from Mitsubishi.

Why it matters

It gave South Korea a car industry of its own. The Pony was exported to many countries, including Canada, where it became a best-seller in the mid-1980s, and it set Hyundai on the path to becoming one of the world's biggest car makers.

Did you know? The same designer, Giugiaro, also styled the first Volkswagen Golf.

Hindustan Ambassador

Hindustan Motors | 1958 - 2014

At a glance

Maker	Hindustan Motors
Country	India
Years built	1958 - 2014
Engine	1.5 L petrol (launch), later diesel options
Power	About 50 hp (launch)
Number built	Hundreds of thousands

The story

The Ambassador was based on the British Morris Oxford Series III and built at Uttarpara, near Kolkata. It was big, tough, and could handle bad roads and heavy loads with little maintenance.

Why it matters

For decades it was the car of Indian government officials and the familiar shape of taxis in Kolkata and elsewhere. Its rounded silhouette became one of the best-known images of India.

Did you know? The Ambassador stayed in production for 56 years, making it one of the longest-produced car designs in the world.

Maruti 800

Maruti Udyog (with Suzuki) | 1983 - 2014

At a glance

Maker	Maruti Udyog (with Suzuki)
Country	India
Years built	1983 - 2014
Engine	796 cc three-cylinder
Power	About 37 hp
Number built	About 2.9 million

The story

The Maruti 800 was the result of a partnership between the Indian government and Japan's Suzuki, and was based on the Suzuki Alto. It was small, modern, fuel-efficient and priced for the growing Indian middle class.

Why it matters

It is often said to have 'put India on wheels'. The 800 changed what Indian buyers expected from a car and laid the foundation for Maruti Suzuki, now India's largest car maker.

Did you know? The first customer, Harpal Singh, received his car keys from Prime Minister Indira Gandhi on 14 December 1983.

Tata Nano

Tata Motors | 2008 - 2018

At a glance

Maker	Tata Motors
Country	India
Years built	2008 - 2018
Engine	624 cc two-cylinder, rear-mounted
Power	About 37 hp
Number built	About 275,000

The story

Ratan Tata was moved by the sight of whole families riding on a single scooter in the rain. He challenged his engineers to build a safe, weatherproof car for around one lakh rupees. The Nano was unveiled at the Auto Expo in Delhi in January 2008.

Why it matters

It was promoted as the world's cheapest car and drew attention from engineers everywhere for its low-cost design ideas. Although sales fell short of hopes, it started a global conversation about truly affordable cars.

Did you know? To save space and cost, early Nanos had only one windscreen wiper and no opening boot lid.

Wuling Hongguang Mini EV

SAIC-GM-Wuling | 2020 - present

At a glance

Maker	SAIC-GM-Wuling
Country	China
Years built	2020 - present
Engine	Rear-mounted electric motor
Power	About 27 hp
Number built	Hundreds of thousands

The story

The Mini EV is a tiny four-seat electric city car designed to be as cheap as possible. At launch the basic version cost less than 30,000 yuan, far below most electric cars. It has a short range, but that is enough for daily trips around town.

Why it matters

It quickly became one of the best-selling electric cars in the world. It showed how quickly electric cars could spread when they were priced for ordinary buyers, and it reflects China's rise as the world's largest car and electric vehicle market.

Did you know? Owners in China often customise their Mini EVs with colourful wraps and accessories.

Holden Commodore

Holden (General Motors) | 1978 - 2020

At a glance

Maker	Holden (General Motors)
Country	Australia
Years built	1978 - 2020
Engine	Six-cylinder and V8
Power	Varies by generation
Number built	Millions

The story

The first Commodore was based on the German Opel Rekord and Senator, but it was reworked for tough Australian conditions. Later generations were designed largely in Australia, with rear-wheel drive and plenty of space for families.

Why it matters

The Commodore was Australia's best-selling car for fifteen years in a row and a fixture of the Bathurst 1000 motor race. Local production ended in 2017, closing an important chapter in Australian manufacturing.

Did you know? Its long rivalry with the Ford Falcon divided Australian families and friends for decades.